COMEBACK FOR PANDIAN?



More than a year after "quitting active politics", **V.K. Pandian** was spotted by **Naveen Patnaik**'s side. First holding the former CM's hand outside a Bhubaneswar hospital, then huddling with docs like a worried next of kin. Could the Tamil-born ex-IAS officer be staging a comeback, after being blamed for the BJD's rout in the 2024 state polls? Patnaik's newly rejigged Political Affairs Committee is packed with Pandian's pals, upsetting the veterans. The man may have exited stage left, but he still seems to be dictating the script.

SUPPORT DEFICIT



Many may see **Tejashwi Yadav** as Bihar's CM-apparent, but few are willing to say it out loud. Elder brother Tej Pratap Yadav snapped "*Faltu baat mat karo*" to chants of "*Abki baar Tejashwi sarkar*" on Aug. 31. Earlier, Rahul Gandhi, on stage with the RJD scion during the Voter Adhikar Yatra, sidestepped a direct question on the issue. The only ringing endorsement came from Akhilesh Yadav, but then the SP has nary an MLA in Bihar.

THE SILENT WARRIORS



Acknowledgement is rare for the Indian Railway Traffic Service (IRTS). Except when you hear of how they moved 17,000 trains in 45 days during the Mahakumbh. Or transported men and material in the COVID years. The latest endorsement came from army chief **Gen. Upendra Dwivedi,** who wrote to Railway Board chairman **Satish Kumar** praising the Railways' work during Op. Sindoor. Citing the mobilisation of an ammunition rake at Pulgaon within 24 hours as a "new benchmark in civil-mil cooperation", he acknowledged the work of 16 IRTS officers. A well-deserved pat on the back.

Kaushik Deka with Avaneesh Mishra, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava and Avishek G. Dastidar

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

SALT WARS

The jury is still out on whether iodine is hero or villain, as the Madurai bench of the Madras High Court deliberated on the subject. The science remains unequivocal: iodine deficiency can cause goitre, hypothyroidism and irreversible developmental delays. In the most severe cases, lack of iodine during pregnancy results in cretinism—a condition of stunted growth and profound mental impairment in children. The World Health Organization estimates that over 1.9 billion people worldwide are at risk of iodine deficiency, making it one of the leading causes of preventable brain damage. And iodisation through common salt remains the best and easiest method to enrich diets with iodine.

Iodine naysayers warn of cancer risk, thyroid inflammation and goitre. A salt traders' association, in a petition to the court, argued that compulsory iodisation curtails consumer choice. The court on its part did not strike down the ban on non-iodised salt, but issued notices to the Union health ministry and the food safety department of Tamil Nadu for their response.

Public health experts advocate stronger monitoring of iodine levels, robust quality controls and clear labelling so that consumers know whether their salt is iodised. This transparency is already the norm globally: in the United States, packets must specify 'iodised' or 'non-iodised'. In the European Union, iodine content must be declared on labels, though policies vary across member-states. In the UK, fortification is voluntary, but if iodine is added, labels must specify it.

Dr Rajan Sankar, one of India's foremost iodine



policy experts, believes mandatory iodisation should continue "because it (not doing so) would cost so many their health". History bears this out. When mandatory iodisation was lifted in 2000, household usage of iodised salt dropped from approximately 72 per cent in 1998-99 to around 54 per cent in 2002-03, disrupting iodine intake across millions of families and causing a surge in iodine deficiency disorders. We cannot afford to repeat that mistake—a little iodine goes a long way for your brain's health.